

Reaching for the moon

At NASA, Katherine was invited to work on complex projects to get spacecraft into Earth's orbit and beyond. Her calculations helped to launch the first American astronauts into space, to put the first humans on the moon (and get them off again!), and to return the broken Apollo 13 spacecraft safely back to Earth. After she retired, Katherine was honored with the Presidential Medal of Freedom. She said though that her greatest reward was the work itself—she loved going to work every single day.

You tell me
when you want it and
where you want it to land,
and I'll do it backward
and tell you when
to take off.

Human computers

Along with Mary Jackson and Dorothy Vaughan, Katherine was part of a computing unit made up of brilliant African-American mathematicians, led by Dorothy. Their calculations, completed with pen and paper, made the first US space missions possible. Later, Mary became NASA's first Black female engineer.



Mary Jackson



Dorothy Vaughan